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6. The Spiny Path of Salvation. Linear and Cyclical Structures of History in Joachim of Fiore.

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1. The Calabrian Abbot.

Medieval conceptions of history would not be the same without the Calabrian Abbot Joachim of Fiore (d. 1202), nor, according to many theologians and historians, would our modern conceptions. Although Joachim of Fiore's name is still tainted with the suspicion of heresy, none other than Joseph Ratzinger claimed as early as 1959 that it was he who, with his Trinitarian theology of history, truly established Jesus Christ as center and turning point in history.¹ Today, Joachim remains inextricably bound with the idea of progress as a new element in the medieval history of ideas.

None of these statements may rest undisputed, and none uncommented. Too often Joachim of Fiore has been regarded as a monolithic exception, a lone voice in the wilderness of the dark ages. But in fact Joachim of Fiore is merely one more link in the long chain of scholarly traditions from Antiquity to the Middle Ages. He was by far no untrained autodidact, but a well-read scholar and an expert in using state-of-the-art exegetical methods. Hence, from a medieval standpoint, his works have to be considered not as remote and obscure theological writings, but rather as some of the most interesting contributions to the so-called renaissance of the 12th century.²

When Joachim was born, Calabria was host to the confluence of political currents that would draw together the Staufian Empire and the Norman-Sicilian Kingdom.³ Joachim had spent some time at the Norman-Sicilian Court and traveled, maybe in his function as a would-be notary or diplomat of the king, to the Holy Land, before he renounced the world in a fashion probably

¹ RATZINGER 1959, p. 108.

² On this 'renaissance' and its history, see HASKINS 1927; BENSON / CONSTABLE 1982, and most recently NOBLE / VAN ENGEN 2012.

³ On Joachim's life, work and *Wirkungsgeschichte*, see REEVES 1969; on his biography, see GRUNDMANN 1977 (1960), and WANNENMACHER 2013b.

similar to that of his younger fellow-countryman Francis of Assisi in order to become a hermit. Even as a monk he never lived the life of a hermit for long. Soon he was made abbot, traveled to other monasteries, and conversed with the kings and popes of his time. His reputation was that of a prophet and an expert on the Antichrist, and his advice much sought-after; his writings and theories were soon discussed not only in his homeland, but traveled as far as Paris and reached, probably still in his own lifetime or else soon after his death, Northern Germany and England.⁴

2. Medieval Conceptions of Time and History.

Western medieval conceptions of time and history are largely based on Augustinian conceptions, which in their turn were deeply rooted in classical education and scholarly traditions of the Late Antiquity, mostly Neo-Platonism. They are fundamentally different from other, non-Western or contemporary Western conceptions by their distinctly teleological character (the idea that history aims at a predestined end), and are generally subsumed under the modern appellation of 'history of salvation'. Our first task is not to understand the medieval conception of time and history, but our own. In his much-discussed review of Karl Löwith, the Jewish-Christian Philosopher Helmut Kuhn states:

Modern man sees with one eye of faith and one eye of reason. Consequently, his view of history is confused. For centuries, the history of the Western world has been viewed from the Christian or classical standpoint – from a deep faith in a Kingdom of God or a belief in recurrent and eternal life-circles. The modern mind, however, is neither Christian nor pagan – and its interpretations of history are Christian in derivation and anti-Christian in result.⁵

Such is the position of modern Western concepts of time. What Kuhn called 'a deep faith in a Kingdom of God', the firm conviction that history has a beginning and will have an end at a predetermined moment which is known to God alone, and that all history has a final aim to reach, had been common sense from ancient times until recently. Even among modern philosophers, the idea that history is ordained to a certain end is not totally extinct. Dealing with ancient, medieval and early modern times one would be ill-advised not to be aware of this fact, and even more so in comparison with other, non-European cultural traditions.

On the way to our modern conception of time and history as something which is unlimited, endless and without final destination, we often regard the Era of Enlightenment as a crucial step, separating us from the dark times of the

⁴ On the reception of Joachim's ideas see BLOOMFIELD / REEVES 1975 and ANDREWS forthcoming.

⁵ KUHN 1949, p. 822.

Middle Ages and their dismal and paralyzing apocalyptic beliefs, and freeing us to pursue life, liberty of thought, and progress in science. But this is not necessarily a one-way road. In an article of the German weekly magazine *DIE ZEIT*, we are told that it was the Age of Enlightenment which allegedly enabled us to laugh and discuss freely, to amuse ourselves, and to create and enjoy personal computers and painless dental treatment, but also environmental pollution, factory farming and nuclear incidents.⁶ But it is really the Age of Enlightenment to which we owe all these wondrous achievements? Us, the West, and not the Chinese nor the Maya or any other non-Western culture?

A decade ago, Frankfurt medievalist Johannes Fried argued that there might be at least one other way to understand modernity:

Western Apocalypticism, which had been omnipresent for centuries, is a collective way of thought and the western mode of explaining and giving sense to history. The whole history of Europe is filled with it, and it formed the mental, social and material culture of Europe.⁷

Fried is convinced that ‘Western Apocalypticism’, a concept of time which is determined by an imminent end that is soon to come, has caused humans to ceaselessly calculate and to try to figure out exactly when and how this end would come. It led them to interpret the signs of the time in terms of prophecies about the end of the world and the final judgment. It undermined all forms of religious fundamentalism by allowing or even forcing Christianity to permanently integrate foreign scholarly traditions from pagan, Jewish and even Muslim sources, in order to safeguard what was worth saving, and thereby enable Christians to be prepared for the impending tribulations, the end of time and the final stage of bliss. An example of Fried’s theory could be the French Franciscan alchemist Jean de Roquetaillade, who died in a papal prison in Avignon in 1365, and had declared alchemy as well as exegesis as a means to survive the perils of the Antichrist.⁸

Indeed, what Fried does – and perhaps the full force of his idea has not yet been sufficiently considered by his academic readership – is simply to turn upside down the usual dichotomy between the stagnation of the dark Middle Ages and the progressiveness of the Era of Enlightenment. This, in turn, implies that it is not a rationalistic Enlightenment (whether an historical epoch or a worldview) which necessarily enables science and progress, but rather the firm expectation and the vivid imagination of a last judgment and an endpoint to history. Furthermore, as a consequence, it is not a culture lacking Enlightenment that cannot achieve progress, but one without some form of apocalyp-

⁶ STAAS 2012.

⁷ FRIED 2011 (my translation).

⁸ DEVUN 2009.

ticism, such as that bequeathed to the modern West in the form of its Judaeo-Christian heritage and set aside beginning with the Enlightenment.

In his famous *Meaning in History*, the German-born philosopher Karl Löwith explains the consequences of the attitude of Jewish-Christian thought towards history:

It is the privilege of theology and philosophy, as contrasted with the sciences, to ask questions that cannot be answered on the basis of empirical knowledge. All the ultimate questions concerning first and last things are of this character; they remain significant because no answer can silence them. They signify a fundamental quest; for there would be no search for the meaning of history if its meaning were manifest in historical events. It is the very absence of meaning in the events themselves that motivates the quest. Conversely, it is only within a pre-established horizon of ultimate meaning, however hidden it may be, that actual history seems to be meaningless. This horizon has been established by history, for it is Hebrew and Christian thinking that brought this colossal question into existence. To ask earnestly the question of the ultimate meaning of history takes one's breath away; it transports us into a vacuum which only hope and faith can fill.⁹

And he continues:

To the Jews and Christians ... history was primarily a history of salvation, and, as such, the proper concern of prophets, preachers, and teachers. The very existence of a philosophy of history and its quest for a meaning is due to the history of salvation; it emerged from the faith in an ultimate purpose. In the Christian era political history, too, was under the influence and in the predicament of this theological background. In some way the destinies of nations became related to a divine or pseudo-divine vocation.¹⁰

According to Löwith (and others, like the theologian Jürgen Moltmann after him), it is mainly in the Judeo-Christian perspective that the future is the true focus of history. Modern thought does not try to discover God's plan in history any more. In his search for a sense or meaning in history, or even his own existence, man is left alone. But things were otherwise for medieval man.

Oftentimes we hear that the omnipresence of death in medieval times caused man to think of nothing but his own imminent death. It is said to determine and dominate the attitude to life for everybody in antique, medieval and early modern times, but especially in the Middle Ages. Its peak was in the 14th century with the *ars moriendi*, the art of dying. Indeed, the discovery of the individual in the 13th century resulted not only in the invention of purgatory, but also of the pressing question of what would happen with the individual soul after the death of the individual, and the institution of the particular judgment of each soul. An important text which perfectly illustrates this attitude towards death is the following portion of a medieval liturgy. Since Baroque times, this Antiphon had been ascribed to Notker, the Poet of St. Gallen, also

⁹ LÖWITH 1949, p. 3–4.

¹⁰ LÖWITH 1949, p. 5.

called Notker the Stammerer, lat. Balbulus, d. 912; but its actual date and origin are unknown, and it is believed to have been written in France or England rather than at St. Gallen:

<i>Media vita in morte sumus</i>	In the midst of life we are in death:
<i>quem quærimus adiutorem,</i>	of whom may we seek for succor,
<i>nisi te, Domine,</i>	but of thee, O Lord,
<i>Qui pro peccatis nostris</i>	Who for our sins
<i>iuste irasceris?</i>	art justly displeased? Yet,
<i>Sancte Deus,</i>	O Lord God most holy,
<i>Sancte fortis,</i>	O Lord most mighty,
<i>Sancte misericors Salvator,</i>	O holy and most merciful Saviour,
<i>amaræ morti ne tradas nos.</i>	deliver us not into the bitter pains of death.

The Antiphon has a long and interesting history with many highlights. One of them was in the second half of the 15th century, when nuns from convents in northern Germany were to be reformed against their will and seemed to have used the Antiphon as a malediction, which made the would-be Reformers tremble in shock and awe.¹¹

The idea of the permeability of borders between life and death, between earth, heaven and the netherworld, which is expressed in the Antiphon, is of course not only medieval, but is also already described in the Old Testament as well as in Greek mythology. In the book of Genesis, Jacob dreams of a ladder, on which angels climb up and down between earth and heaven. In Greek mythology, the gods are able to enter and leave the human sphere whenever, and wherever, they want to. As well as the Celts or the Germans, the Greeks and Romans, too, knew many places where such a contact was regularly due to happen, most of all Sicily and especially the region around Mt. Etna, which was known as a gateway to the netherworld. This belief even continued well into Late Antiquity, as Theodoric the Great was also said to dwell in Mt. Etna after his death, an early fore-father of the Emperor of the Holy Roman Empire Frederick I. of Hohenstaufen, who would later be said to rest in the Kyffhäuser and be informed by the ravens, and his grandson Frederick II., who after his death was said to be ‘dead, and not dead’, and was expected to come back any time since.

Such a worldview was based on a conception of time and history as ordained by God, the knowledge of which could be obtained by revelation, experience and tradition. Creation itself, nature and everything in it, as well as history, were considered as a book, written by God, full of signs and revelations, waiting for man to discover it. The visible world was thought of as surrounded by the invisible, the world of spirits, able and often willing to enter the natural world at any given moment. Man thus saw himself placed between heaven and hell, both of which were very near to him, and he was always

¹¹ On the Antiphon and its reception see HASCHER-BURGER 2011.

aware of the numerous possibilities of his own near end and the nearness of the end of the world. But over all, he was absolutely convinced that history was determined and ordered by a predestined plan. In his novel *Sir Nigel* (1906), set in the Hundred Years' War, the British romancier Arthur Conan Doyle described this conception of life most aptly and beautifully:

In those simple times there was a great wonder and mystery in life. Man walked in fear and solemnity, with Heaven very close above his head, and hell very close below his feet. God's visible hand was everywhere, in the rainbow and in the comet, in the thunder and the wind...¹²

Man was therefore always keen to discover and to understand the main structures of this master plan, in order to know what present events were meant to signify, and what the future had in store for him. Medieval historical writing is full of examples showing the impact of spiritual perception in history, of firm belief in the agency of God's own hand, of obedience or the consequences of disobedience to divine signs which were making manifest the will of God, all proving the deeply rooted perception of nature and history as an open book. In a famous novel from the 1980s, the author Umberto Eco makes us witness of a conversation between a young monk and his teacher, who is explaining this worldview:

'My good Adso', my master said, 'during our whole journey I have been teaching you to recognize the evidence through which the world speaks to us like a great book. Alanus de Insulis said that *omnis mundi creatura / quasi liber et pictura / nobis est in speculum*, and he was thinking of the endless array of symbols with which God, through His creatures, speaks to us of the eternal life. But the Universe is even more talkative than Alanus thought, and it speaks not only of the ultimate things (which it does always in an obscure fashion) but also of closer things, and then it speaks quite clearly.'¹³

William of Baskerville, in *The Name of the Rose*, reminds us about the following, much-cited verses illustrating this all-overruling awareness and ascribed to Alain de Lille (12th century):

<i>Omnis mundi creatura</i>	All creature on earth
<i>quasi liber et pictura</i>	like a book or a painting
<i>nobis est in speculum</i>	for us like a mirror
<i>nostrae vitae, nostrae sortis,</i>	of our life, our fate,
<i>nostrae status, nostrae mortis</i>	our station, our death
<i>fidele signaculum.</i>	a true sign. ¹⁴

The man of the Middle Ages experienced a deep consciousness of the continuous presence of the otherworld, of heaven as well as of hell and netherworld,

¹² DOYLE 1906, p. 12.

¹³ ECO 1983, p. 23–24.

¹⁴ *Magistri Alani Rhythmus alter, quo graphice natura hominis fluxa et caduca depingitur* in PL 210, col. 579 (my translation).

of our own mortality and the unceasing attempt of men to discern and read the deeds of God in the signs of the time. The book of nature, and history, lies open before us, we only need to look into it, and read the signs. The underlying structure of history is already existent, men can only re-discover, not generate it. What is crucial is that this knowledge refers not only to the past, but covers the remaining future period until the last judgment and the end of the world as well. Such a knowledge was based on the writings of the Old and New Testament and the Church Fathers, who had an acute awareness of living in the last stage of the world, when an imminent crisis and culmination of bliss and terror would precede the second coming of Christ. The Christian image of the end of the World found its oldest normative expression in the creeds of Nicene and Constantinople, as decreed in the fourth century:

<i>Et resurrexit tertia die,</i>	On the third day he rose again
<i>secundum Scripturas,</i>	in accordance with the Scriptures;
<i>et ascendit in cælum,</i>	he ascended into heaven
<i>sedet ad dexteram Patris.</i>	and is seated at the right hand of the Father.
<i>Et iterum venturus est cum gloria</i>	He will come again in glory to judge the
<i>iudicare vivos et mortuos</i>	living and the dead,
<i>cuius regni non erit finis</i>	and his kingdom will have no end. ¹⁵

To be able to understand the structure of God's plan, and to prepare himself for the future tribulations and bliss, man always worked history into smaller partitions, the schemas for which he found in the Holy Scripture.

The most influential scheme for Christianity is to be found in the book of Daniel in the Old Testament, written between 170 and 160 BC. It is probably based on a much older conception of the Ages of Men, which might be of Persian origin and was to be found in Hesiod's poem 'Works and Days' from the 8th or early 7th century BC, where the Greek author describes the Golden Age, the Silver Age, the Bronze Age, the Heroic Age and the Iron Age, of which generally each one deteriorates in comparison with its predecessors.

In the Book of Daniel, the prophet Daniel explains King Nebuchadnezzar's dream of a statue composed of sections corresponding to similarly deteriorating materials by identifying each material with a single kingdom. A few verses later, the prophet himself has a similar vision: this time, however, the vision contains four beasts, the fourth bearing eleven horns, signifying four subsequent kingdoms, which will dominate the time from his own presence until the very end, when a man in white clothes will come to slay them and take their power. When Daniel is troubled by what he saw, the dream is then explained to him by an *angelus interpretes*, and Daniel hears:

¹⁵ DENZINGER *et al.* ³⁷1991, n° 150, 84. The English version follows the Book of Common Prayer.

The fourth beast shall be the fourth kingdom upon earth, which shall be diverse from all kingdoms, and shall devour the whole earth, and shall tread it down, and break it in pieces.

And the ten horns out of this kingdom are ten kings that shall arise: and another shall rise after them; and he shall be diverse from the first, and he shall subdue three kings.

And he shall speak great words against the most High, and shall wear out the saints of the most High, and think to change times and laws: and they shall be given into his hand until a time and times and the dividing of time.

But the judgment shall sit, and they shall take away his dominion, to consume and to destroy it unto the end.

And the kingdom and dominion, and the greatness of the kingdom under the whole heaven, shall be given to the people of the saints of the most High, whose kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey him.

Hitherto is the end of the matter.¹⁶

Here we must infer that Löwith is not entirely right with his presupposition that the Greco-Roman world possessed no real hope in a better future. To the contrary: centuries later, Hesiod's remembrance of the glorious past, of the Golden Age which would never come back, was revived and transformed into the expectation of a Golden Age which was yet to come. And in one particular case, it would have a remarkable influence on the Christian world. Around 40 BC, the Roman poet Virgil wrote:

*Vltima Cumaei venit iam carminis
aetas / magnus ab integro saeculorum
nascitur ordo / iam redit et Virgo
redeunt Saturnia regna / iam noua
progenies caelo demittitur alto / tu
modo nascenti puero quo ferrea
primum / desinet ac toto surget gens
aurea mundo / casta faue Lucina tu-
us iam regnat Apollo.*

Now the last age by Cumae's Sibyl sung /
Has come and gone, and the majestic roll /
Of circling centuries begins anew: / Justice
returns, returns old Saturn's reign, / With a
new breed of men sent down from heaven. /
Only do thou, at the boy's birth in whom /
The iron shall cease, the golden race arise, /
Befriend him, chaste Lucina, 'tis thine own
Apollo reigns.¹⁷

¹⁶ Dan. 7.23–28 (in the Latin version): *Bestia quarta regnum quartum erit in terra quod maius erit omnibus regnis et deuorabit uniuersam terram et conculcabit et comminuet eam. Porro cornua decem ipsius regni decem reges erunt et alius consurget post eos et ipse potentior erit prioribus et tres reges humiliabit. Et sermones contra Excelsum loquetur et sanctos Altissimi conteret et putabit quod possit mutare tempora et leges et tradentur in manu eius usque ad tempus et tempora et dimidium temporis. Et iudicium sedebit ut auferatur potentia et conteratur et dispereat usque in finem. Regnum autem et potestas et magnitudo regni quae est subter omne caelum detur populo sanctorum Altissimi cuius regnum regnum sempiternum est et omnes reges seruient ei et obedient. Hucusque finis uerbi.*

¹⁷ VERG., *Ecl.* 4.5–18 (transl. J.B. GREENOUGH, 1900).

By proclaiming the coming of a God-like child, later identified by Virgil himself with Augustus, the first Roman emperor, the Roman poet Virgil seemed to have given word to the everlasting hope into the coming of the Messiah, which was how later Christian readers interpreted this text. And by having foreseen the Messiah, the pagan Sibyls entered the hall of fame of Christian prophets, never to leave it again. Their role of prophetesses of Christ is the reason why the pagan Sibyls can be found sitting together with the prophets from the Old Testament on the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel, painted by Michelangelo Buonarroti (1508-1512).

Since Virgil and his vision of a Golden Age which is still to come, the linear structure of ever more deteriorating stages of historical development as described by Hesiod and Daniel ceased to be the only possible conception of history. The new alternative turned the motive of deterioration upside-down, and in the midst of the 'earth and clay', a new Golden Age could begin, though it is difficult to decide whether this new age was considered as the beginning of a new circle of history or rather as the anticlimax of a linear development.

A simpler and more clear-cut partition of time and history emerged with the development of the idea of the 'six (or seven) ages' of the world, a vision whose long-lasting influence ebbed only in modern times. The Nuremberg humanist and cartographer Hartmann Schedel (d. 1514) was by far not the last, though perhaps the most influential writer to use this image of a sixfold history when he wrote his Nuremberg Chronicle, which was soon to be called, after its author, the 'Schedel'sche Weltchronik':

Now there are six ages of the world: The first age is from the Creation of the world to the Flood—a period, according to the Hebrews, of 1656 years; but according to the seventy interpreters, 2242 years, as Isidore fixes it, and many others whom we here follow. So the Hebrews give this age 586 years less; and according to this calculation Methuselah died before the Flood, in the year in which it occurred. The second age is from the Flood to the birth of Abraham, which, according to the Hebrew, lasted 292 years, but according to the seventy interpreters, 942 years; so the Hebrew gives it 650 years less. The reason for this difference I have not been able to find. The third age is from Abraham's birth to the beginning of the Kingdom of David, and, according to the Hebrew, covers a period of 941 years; but according to the seventy interpreters, 940 years. The fourth age is from the beginning of David's Kingdom to the passing of Babylon, and according to the Hebrew, lasted 484 years; but according to the seventy interpreters 485 years. The fifth age is from the passing of Babylon, when Jerusalem was destroyed and the Temple burned, to the blessed Birth of Christ, a period, according to the aforesaid, of 590 years; but concerning this computation there is a great division, for various calculations have been made by sundry persons. The sixth age is from the Birth of Christ to the End of the World, which God alone knows. And this is called the old age, or the last hour. To this may

be added a seventh age, that is, the age of those who are now at rest, and which runs parallel with the sixth. The eighth age is that of the Resurrection.¹⁸

Until late in the 19th century, the Spanish bishop Isidore of Seville (d. 636), was believed to be the author of this well-known partition, described in his encyclopedic and influential 'Books of Etymologies' as following:

<i>Prima aetas est ab Adam usque ad Noe; / secunda a Noe usque ad Abraham; / tertia ab Abraham usque ad David; / quarta a David usque ad transmigrationem Juda in Babyloniam; / quinta deinde usque ad ad- ventum salvatoris in carne; / sexta, quae nunc agitur, usque quo mundus iste fini- atur.</i>	The first age is from Adam to Noah, / the second from Noah to Abraham, / the third from Abraham to David, / the fourth from David to the Babylonian captivity, / the fifth until the advent of the Lord in the flesh, / the sixth, which is now, until the world will end. ¹⁹
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But here, as in most cases, Isidore only collected what was common belief, and here, as often, it was St Augustine, bishop of Hippo (d. 430), who will have been the first to establish what was to become common knowledge.²⁰ Augustine speaks at least twice about the six ages and the final Sabbath. The classical quotation is not in his monumental *City of God*, but in a sermon of the year 393, where Augustine compares the ages of the world with the seven days of Creation. But best known is the final paragraph of the final chapter of the last book of his *City of God*, written roughly two decades later, where Augustine describes the Last Sabbath of Eternity.

In his 22 books on the *City of God*, Augustine of Hippo describes his conception of history and of the origin and fate of humankind, from creation to the last judgment, to the eternal punishment for the damned and the eternal beatitude for the saints. All things were made by God Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, and the Holy Trinity is revealed to us in the creation, so that all members and organs of the incorruptible body, the Holy City, shall 'rest and see', as Augustine writes in the final passage of Book 22. It is here, in his description of what Augustine calls the 'Great Sabbath', which has no evening, that he describes the seven ages of the world according to the seven days of creation, from creation to the eternal Sabbath:

This Sabbath shall appear still more clearly if we count the ages as days, in accordance with the periods of time defined in Scripture, for that period will be found to be

¹⁸ HARTMANN SCHEDEL, *Nuremberg Chronicle*, Nuremberg 1493 (transl. W. Schmauch, Chicago, 1947).

¹⁹ ISID., *Etym.* 5.38.5 (my translation).

²⁰ The best survey in the six ages of the world might still be SCHMIDT 1955–1956. Originally, the scheme of the six ages might even have been inspired by much older sources, deriving probably from ancient Iran; but there is no certainty about that, and in any case it was Augustine's, and later Isidore's model, which preserved the concept of the six (or seven ages) of the world and made it known, and relevant, for the Medieval West.

the seventh. The first age, as the first day, extends from Adam to the deluge; the second from the deluge to Abraham, equaling the first, not in length of time, but in the number of generations, there being ten in each. From Abraham to the advent of Christ there are, as the evangelist Matthew calculates, three periods, in each of which are fourteen generations — one period from Abraham to David, a second from David to the captivity, a third from the captivity to the birth of Christ in the flesh. There are thus five ages in all. The sixth is now passing, and cannot be measured by any number of generations, as it has been said, ‘It is not for you to know the times, which the Father has put in His own power’ (Acts 1:7). After this period God shall rest as on the seventh day, when He shall give us (who shall be the seventh day) rest in Himself. But there is not now space to treat of these ages; suffice it to say that the seventh shall be our Sabbath, which shall be brought to a close, not by an evening, but by the Lord’s day, as an eighth and eternal day, consecrated by the resurrection of Christ, and prefiguring the eternal repose not only of the spirit, but also of the body. There we shall rest and see, see and love, love and praise. This is what shall be in the end without end. For what other end do we propose to ourselves than to attain to the kingdom of which there is no end?²¹

From then on, the stage was set. A hundred years after Augustine, the Scythian monk Dionysius Exiguus, or Dennis the Short, introduced a new mode of numbering the years by beginning with the year of Christ’s birth as the year ‘One’, which he identifies with the year 754 *ab urbe condita*, since the founding of the city of Rome. Two centuries later, the English monk Bede the Venerable (d. 754) used this chronology in his book on English Church History, and in the 11th century, this mode of calculating time was firmly fixed by what was then the Roman Curia. Hence, the seven ages of history are the underlying structure of each and every conception of history in Medieval Western Europe. Not even Joachim of Fiore, with his now famous Trinitarian view of

²¹ AUG., *Civ. Dei* 22.30 (transl. M. DODS, 1913): *Ipse etiam numerus aetatum, uelut dierum, si secundum eos articulos temporis computetur, qui scripturis uidentur expressi, iste sabbatismus euidentius apparebit, quoniam septimus inuenitur; ut prima aetas tamquam primus dies sit ab Adam usque ad diluuium, secunda inde usque ad Abraham, non aequalitate temporum, sed numero generationum; denas quippe habere reperiuntur. Hinc iam, sicut Matthaeus euangelista determinat, tres aetates usque ad Christi subsequuntur aduentum, quae singulae denis et quaternis generationibus explicantur: ab Abraham usque ad Dauid una, altera inde usque ad transmigrationem in Babyloniam, tertia inde usque ad Christi carnalem natiuitatem. Fiunt itaque omnes quinque. Sexta nunc agitur nullo generationum numero metienda propter id quod dictum est: Non est uestrum scire tempora, quae Pater posuit in sua potestate. Post hanc tamquam in die septimo requiescet Deus, cum eundem diem septimum, quod nos erimus, in se ipso Deo faciet requiescere. De istis porro aetatibus singulis nunc diligenter longum est disputare; haec tamen septima erit sabbatum nostrum, cuius finis non erit uespera, sed dominicus dies uelut octauus aeternus, qui Christi resurrectione sacratus est, aeternam non solum spiritus, uerum etiam corporis requiem praefigurans. Ibi uocabimus et uidebimus, uidebimus et amabimus, amabimus et laudabimus. Ecce quod erit in fine sine fine. Nam quis alius noster est finis nisi peruenire ad regnum, cuius nullus est finis?*

history, could go without the sevenfold image,²² though expectedly he put his personal mark on it, thereby changing it – and our image of history itself – forever.²³

Augustine's monumental *City of God* owns its origin to the earnest attempt to understand history in the light of salvation. For when, after the conversion of the Emperor Constantine, the Christians had enjoyed a previously unknown state of peace and security, the fall of Rome in the year 410 changed everything. Many of Augustine's contemporaries blamed the Christian faith as the reason for the downfall of the empire. Many Roman refugees came to the colonies in Northern Africa, and even the remote regions trembled with shock and awe. In the year 411, a man came who was no refugee, but the emperor's commissioner and proconsul, Flavius Marcellinus. He belonged to the Chris-

²² Often as he mentions the six or seven ages of the world or refers to them, Joachim seems to feel no need to explain them, or even to list them up for the reader's benefit; it is therefore quite clear that both for Joachim and his intended readers the ages of the world were common – and indisputable – knowledge. When once in the *Concordia* Joachim does describe the ages, he attributes the numbers of generations to each of the ages: *In septem vero diebus designate sunt septem etates, que isto modo sunt assignande: prima etas ab Adam usque ad Noe, decem generationibus terminata; secunda a Noe usque ad Habraam, decem generationibus terminata; tertia ab Habraam usque ad Booz, decem generationibus terminata; quarto a Booz usque ad Oziam, secundum Matheum dico decem generationibus terminata; quinta ab Ozia usque ad Zorobabel, decem generationibus terminata; sexta a Zorobabel usque ad Christum, decem generationibus terminata; septima etas usque in finem. Ecce isto modo septima etas inchoavit a Iohanne baptista, nimirum quia lex et prophete usque ad Iohannem baptistam, exinde autem libertas, que est in fide et in Spiritu sancto. In eo intellectu, qui pertinet ad Patrem et Filium, usque ad Zachariam etates quinque; sexta vero ab ipso Zacharia usque ad Iovinianum augustum, qui tenuit monarchiam post Iulianum apostatam subputatis et hic generationibus quatuordecim, sicuti suprascript Mattheus, reliquo vero tempore reputato in sabbatum. In eo intellectu qui pertinet ad Filium et Spiritum sanctum inchoandum est ab Ozia rege Iuda. Sunt enim ex eo tempore usque ad presens quasi sex decade generationum. Reliquum vero tempus quod erit usque in finem reputatur sabbatum* (*Concordia novi ac veteris testamenti*, lib. iii, Venice 1519, repr. Frankfurt a. M. 1964, fol. 73rb).

²³ The relation between the traditional six ages of the world (to be followed by the seventh, with the second advent of Christ), the three status of God Father, Son and Holy Spirit, and the times of the church Joachim explains thus: *Non solum autem respectu sex temporum pertinentium ad secundum statum tempus illud quod erit tertii status septimum extimandum est, verum etiam respectu sex etatum mundi, quarum quinque preterierant quando Christus venit in mundum, sexta vero inchoata ex eodem tempore perseverat in labore usque ad hec tempora nostra, in quibus et status secundus in extremis agit et tertius qui erit sabbatum initiatus est* (*Expositio in Apocalypsim*, Liber introductorius, Venice 1527, repr. Frankfurt a. M. 1964, fol. 11va). So the first five ages represent the first *status*, the time of the Father, while the sixth age, beginning with Christ and still continuing, represents the second *status*, the time of the Son, which is in itself divided into six times, while the third *status*, the time of the Holy Spirit, is still to be expected.

tian intellectual elite of Rome, which at that time was deeply split due to differing explanations of the past events, and he came to Augustine to seek his advice and help for understanding the unbelievable. And Augustine answered – in 22 books (and 14 years' worth of work). He declared:

The glorious city of God is my theme in this work, which you, my dearest son Marcellinus, suggested, and which is due to you by my promise. I have undertaken its defense against those who prefer their own gods to the Founder of this city,—a city surpassingly glorious, whether we view it as it still lives by faith in this fleeting course of time, and sojourns as a stranger in the midst of the ungodly, or as it shall dwell in the fixed stability of its eternal seat, which it now with patience waits for, expecting until 'righteousness shall return unto judgment,' and it obtain, by virtue of its excellence, final victory and perfect peace. A great work this, and an arduous; but God is my helper. For I am aware what ability is requisite to persuade the proud how great is the virtue of humility, which raises us, not by a quite human arrogance, but by a divine grace, above all earthly dignities that totter on this shifting scene. For the King and Founder of this city of which we speak, has in Scripture uttered to His people a dictum of the divine law in these words: 'God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble.' But this, which is God's prerogative, the inflated ambition of a proud spirit also affects, and dearly loves that this be numbered among its attributes, to 'Show pity to the humbled soul, And crush the sons of pride.' And therefore, as the plan of this work we have undertaken requires, and as occasion offers, we must speak also of the earthly city, which, though it be mistress of the nations, is itself ruled by its lust of rule.²⁴

This was the final aim of the Christians – to understand history is to understand God's plan. This is why in medieval times, there is no word for 'history of salvation'. Because history is salvation. And following Fried's interpretation, this is not past history, but a job description.

²⁴ AUG., *Civ. Dei, praef.* (transl. M. DODS, 1913): *Gloriosissimam ciuitatem Dei siue in hoc temporum cursu, cum inter impios peregrinatur ex fide uiuens, siue in illa stabilitate sedis aeternae, quam nunc expectat per patientiam, quoadusque iustitia conuertatur in iudicium, deinceps adeptura per excellentiam uictoria ultima et pace perfecta, hoc opere instituto et mea ad te promissione debito defendere aduersus eos, qui conditori eius deos suos praeferunt, fili carissime Marcelline, suscepi, magnum opus et arduum, sed Deus adiutor noster est. Nam scio quibus uiribus opus sit, ut persuadeatur superbis quanta sit uirtus humilitatis, qua fit ut omnia terrena cacumina temporali mobilitate nutantia non humano usurpata fastu, sed diuina gratia donata celsitudo transcendat. Rex enim et conditor ciuitatis huius, de qua loqui instituimus, in scriptura populi sui sententiam diuinae legis aperuit, qua dictum est: Deus superbis resistit, humilibus autem dat gratiam. Hoc uero, quod Dei est, superbae quoque animae spiritus inflatus adfectat amatque sibi in laudibus dici: Parcere subiectis et debellare superbos. Vnde etiam de terrena ciuitate, quae cum dominari adpetit, etsi populi seruiant, ipsa ei dominandi libido dominatur, non est praetereundum silentio quidquid dicere suscepti huius operis ratio postulat si facultas datur.*

3. *The Signs of the Times: Reading Joachim of Fiore.*²⁵

Up to now, we have only been talking about the linear structures of medieval conceptions of time. But there is more than that. By the second century AD, Christianity was given a striking example of cyclical structures in history as well. The idea has not one father, but at least three: John of Patmos, Victorinus of Pettau (d. 303/304), and Tyconius. Its foster-parent, who helped it make its first steps into the building of tradition of Christian thought, was none other but the afore-mentioned Augustine of Hippo. The last book of the bible, containing what Jerome called *Tot sacramenta quot verba*,²⁶ provided Christianity with the most important, urgent and obscure information about its future fate, about future tribulations and bliss, the end of the world and the coming of the heavenly Jerusalem. While John of Patmos gives no explanation of his text, Victorinus and most of all Tyconius, a Donatist author of the 4th century, teach us to understand the Apocalypse and its visions not as linear, but as a pattern of subsequent circles, in which each one contains the same complete history as all together. Tyconius even wrote a book of exegetical rules, among which the *recapitulatio* became the most influential one, which was possible only because Augustine himself adopted and copied the (heretic) Donatist rules and published them within his own works.

Applying the Tyconian rule of recapitulation, according to which each of the seven visions contains the complete history until the end, *and* they all together depict the same history on a larger scale, Joachim of Fiore constructed a parallel of sequences of seven or eight seals and openings, and was convinced of the *plenitudo* of the Apocalypse, which contains and depicts the complete history from the beginning to its expected end:

Blessed is he, says Revelation, who reads and hears the words of this prophecy, and keeps in his mind, what is written in here.²⁷ For it contains in it not only the present prophecy, however it may be, but, if we understand it in the right way, it comprehends any other prophecy as well, and what is more, it comprehends and opens it. Other prophecies brought forward either only a few details or only obscure information, which referred to the battles of single peoples foreshadowing the future ones; the present prophecy (i. e. Revelation) opens up generally everything, reveals the secret, opens the bindings of the seals, and enlightens the dark.²⁸

²⁵ On Joachim's conception of history see REEVES 1977/1999.

²⁶ HIER., *Ep.* 53 (*Ad Paulinum de studio scripturarum*), CSEL 54, p. 463. On patristic and medieval exegesis of the Apocalypse, see BOUSSET ⁶1906 (on this passage p. 62) ; WANNENMACHER 2005, p. 16 with n. 30.

²⁷ *Rev.* 1.3.

²⁸ 'Beatus', ait, 'qui legit et qui audit verba prophetie huius et servat ea que in ea scripta sunt.' Non enim hec prophetia qualiscumque est, sed omnium aliarum – si sane sapimus – prophetia, utpote que omnes aut pene omnes comprehendit in unum et, quod eo maius est, comprehendit et aperit. Alie namque prophetie aut pauca aut obscura

This role and function of the Revelation was not disclosed to Joachim by applying the scholarly methods which he displays so expertly elsewhere, but by a vision, revealing the historical contents and the key position of Revelation in the history of salvation:

When in that same night (i. e. the night before Easter) something similar happened, around the silent midnight, I believe, and the hour when our lion from the tribe of Judah is believed to have risen from the death, suddenly something occurred before my inner eyes, during my meditations, in great clarity about the completeness of this book (i. e. Revelation), and the complete concordance of the Old and the New Testament was revealed to me.²⁹

He described the method of the Apocalypse's author thus:

The battles of the church are described altogether and one after the other, and the orders and the battles are distinguished by the schedules of the times, in perfect concordance with the past, thereby demonstrating that everything that preceded in the image of the people of the Hebrews must be completed in the church of Christ. And it was not written down disorderly, so that the first things were described lastly and the last first, and the reader is presented with difficulties, but rather in such a way that there can be no doubt that future events will follow one after the other, and he distinguishes the single parts, as we shall show later on, and in each part the *recapitulatio* starts anew.³⁰

In his lengthy commentary on the book of Revelation, the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*,³¹ first (and lastly) printed in Venice in 1527, Joachim showed how well he had learned the exegetic rules, and demonstrated how skilful he applied them, introducing himself as a scholar who was both well-read in the scholarly tradition of the Latin church and acquainted with ongoing debates, but also self-confident and courageous enough to remain steadfast, albeit with due reverence to the authorities, wherever the results of his own research lead him

protulerunt, specialium populorum bella in typo futurorum tangentes ; hec generaliter occulta reserat, patefacit archana, solvit sigillorum vincula, tenebrosa illustrat. (Expositio in Apocalypsim, Liber introductorius, fol. 3rb–va)

²⁹ *Ibid.*: Cum ergo in supra scripta nocte simile aliquid contigisset, circa medium ut opinor noctis silentium et hora qua leo noster de tribu iuda resurrexisse extimatur a mortuis, subito michi meditati aliquid quadam mentis oculis intelligentie claritate percepta de plenitudine libri huius et tota veteris ac novi testamenti concordia revelatio facta est. (lib. I, fol. 39va)

³⁰ *Ibid.*: Ita ecclesiastica prelia summatim et seriatim prosequitur, ita per curricula temporum ordines et bella distinguit, ut tamen a veteribus non discordet, ostendens oportere compleri in ecclesia Christi quecunque in Ebreorum populo in figura preceserant. Nec confuso id ordine factum esse, ut prima ultima et ultima prima scribantur ac per hoc lector difficultate sibi facta diffidat, sed ut futura erant per tempora succedentia sibi scripta esse non dubitet, ita tamen ut partes singulas prout infra ostendemus distinguat, et in singulis partibus recapitulatio fiat. (Liber introductorius, fol. 3va)

³¹ JOACHIM OF FIORE, *Expositio super Apocalypsim*, Venice, 1527 (repr. Frankfurt am Main, 1964). Not much has been written on Joachim's commentary yet; see WANNENMACHER 2011; EAD. 2014.

to novel conclusions. For Joachim, history according to the Apocalypse was a revolving story, beginning over and over again, seven times in all, from the first day of creation to the final Sabbath. But Joachim did not stop there.

Another traditional method of explaining history with the eyes of faith, to which Joachim dedicated a whole book, was the idea of the concordances between the Old and the New Testament, between God's people of old – the Jews – and God's actual people, the Christians. The first examples of this practice can be found in the writings of the Apostle Paul, where he compares characters from the Old Testament with those from the new dispensation, his own contemporaries. Nearly twelve centuries later, Joachim did the same, with the only difference that he could parallel not only his own contemporaries like St Paul did, but all kings and saints, popes and persecutors, dead or alive or still to be coming. History, following this model of concordances, was a series of two parallel lines, the old and the new dispensation, the Old Testament and the New Testament (together with the church history), God's people of old, the Jews, and his new people, the Christians, who stemmed not only from Israel, but also included gentiles. One of Joachims' three main works therefore deals with the Concordances between Old and New Testament, and the past, present and future of Christianity as represented in these two parallel streams of history from their respective beginnings to the end.³² But even with these two models – the seven visions of the Apocalypse as described in his *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, and the two parallel streams as described in the *Liber de Concordia* – Joachim's image of history was not yet complete.

In Joachim's time, there were several topics which dominated the theological debates. The major subject theologians of the twelfth century – who were the first to talk of 'theology' rather than of single theological issues – discussed was the Holy Trinity. Another topic was eschatology and the end of the world, a debate influenced not only by academic concerns, but also by contemporary political issues. Joachim was neither the first nor probably even the most characteristic twelfth-century theologian to consider the three persons of the Godhead as referring also to the underlying structure of history. Shortly before Joachim, the theologians of the so-called German Symbolism had done so as well, most notably Rupert of Deutz, Anselm of Havelberg and Otto of Freising.³³ Similar to them but in much greater detail, Joachim divided history into three parts, the time of the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. The time of the Father began with the old dispensation; the time of the Son began, of course, with the nativity, though his preexistence is always presupposed. The

³² JOACHIM OF FIORE, *Concordia novi ac veteris testamenti*, Venice, 1519 (repr. Frankfurt am Main, 1964; see the ed. (parts I–IV only) by E. Randolph Daniel, Philadelphia, 1983). On the concords, see DANIEL, 2001.

³³ On the conceptions of history prevailing among the group of the so-called 'Deutsche Symbolisten', see RAUH ²1998. The classical reference is DEMPFF ²1954.

time of the Holy Spirit, however, began secretly, when the resurrected Lord opened up his disciples' senses on the road to Emmaus and when the Spirit was dispensed at Pentecost; it began more openly at the time when Saint Benedict took his vows and established occidental monasticism, *and* it will begin most clearly and completely in Joachim's near future, when the spiritual insight, which is the sign of the third time, the time of the Holy Spirit, will be given to all faithful, and a renewed church will be ready to fight the last battle with the Evil and to finally welcome the heavenly Jerusalem. Joachim explains this underlying structure concisely in his most instructive *Liber introductorius* to the Commentary on Revelation:

The first of the three *status*, about which we want to speak, was under the time of law, when God's people had been very young at that time, laboring under the forces of this world, and not yet able to reach for the liberty of the Spirit, until he would come, who says: *When the Son will set you free, you will be really free.*³⁴ The second *status* was under the Evangel and lasts until now, in freedom compared to the previous *status*, but non compared to the future one. For the Apostle [St Paul] says: *Now we recognize partially, and prophecy partly; but when it will have arrived what is perfect, everything incomplete will disappear.*³⁵ And elsewhere: *The Lord is Spirit, and where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty.*³⁶ The third *status* therefore will be near the end of the world, not any more under the veil of the letter, but in full freedom of the Spirit, when after the destruction of the Pseudo-Evangel of the Son of Perdition and his prophets those, who *educated many people to justice, will be like splendor of heaven, and like stars in all eternity.*³⁷ And the first *status*, which appeared under law and circumcision, began with Adam, the second, which appeared under the Evangel, began with Ozias, and the third, inasmuch can be said calculating from the number of generations, began from the time of Saint Benedict, while his eminent clarity shall be expected near the end, namely at the time, when Elijah will be revealed and the unfaithful people of the Jews will be converted to the Lord,³⁸ so that it seems the Holy Spirit speaking in his own voice claiming in the Scripture: *Until now Father and Son have been at work, and now I will act.*³⁹ For like the letter of the former testament seems to belong with a special likeness to the Father, the letter of the New Testament to belong to the Son, so the spiritual intelli-

³⁴ John 8.36.

³⁵ 1 Cor. 13.9–10.

³⁶ 1 Cor. 3.15.

³⁷ Dan. 12.3.

³⁸ It is remarkable, and typical for Joachim, that in the center and culmination of his very complex and uniquely Joachite conception of time and eschatology he quotes none but Augustine, who in the City of God lists the same traditional elements and events of Judgment Day: *In illo itaque iudicio uel circa illud iudicium has res didicimus esse venturas, Heliam Thesbiten, fidem Iudaeorum, Antichristum persecuturum, Christum iudicaturum, mortuorum resurrectionem, bonorum malorumque diremptionem, mundi conflagrationem ejusdemque renouationem. Quae omnia quidem uentura esse credendum est; sed quibus modis et quo ordine ueniant, magis tunc docebit rerum experientia, quam nunc ad perfectum hominum intelligentia ualet consequi.* (Aug., Civ. Dei 20.30.30, CCSL 48, 757f., l. 165–174, PL 41, col. 708)

³⁹ John 5.17.

gence, which proceeded from both letters, seems to belong to the Holy Spirit. And again, like the order of the married, which arose in the first time, seems to belong due to a certain similarity to the Father, the order of the preachers, who arose in the second time, to the Son, so the order of the monks, to whom the last times are attributed, belongs to the Holy Spirit. And accordingly the first status is ascribed to the Father, the second to the Son, the third to the Holy Spirit, though a status of the world and an elected people must be said in a different mode, and all together belong to the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit.⁴⁰

The shortest of Joachim's three main works, the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, was dedicated to the third person of the Godhead.⁴¹ Here, Joachim asserts not

⁴⁰ JOACHIM OF FIORE: *Primus trium statuum, de quibus nobis sermo, fuit sub tempore leg is, quando populus Domini adhuc pro tempore parvulus serviens erat sub elementis huius mundi non valens adipisci libertatem Spiritus, quousque veniret ille, qui ait: Si Filius vos liberaverit, vere liberi eritis. Secundus status fuit sub evangelio et manet usque nunc in libertate quidem respectu preteriti, sed non in libertate respectu futuri. Dicit enim apostolus: Nunc ex parte cognoscimus et ex parte prophetamus; cum autem venerit quod perfectum est, evacuabitur quod ex parte est. Et alio loco: Dominus autem Spiritus est, et ubi Spiritus Domini, ibi libertas. Tertius ergo status erit circa finem seculi, non iam sub velamine littere, sed in plena Spiritus libertate, quando evacuato et destructo pseudoevangelio Filii perditionis et prophetarum eius hii, qui ad iustitiam erudient multos, erunt sicut splendor firmamenti et quasi stelle in perpetuas eternitates. Et primus quidem status, qui claruit sub lege et circumcissione, initiatus est ab Adam, secundus, qui claruit sub evangelio, initiatus est ab Ozia, tertius, quantum datur intelligi ex numero generationum, a tempore sancti Benedicti; cuius precellens claritas expectanda est circa finem, ex eo videlicet tempore, quo revelabitur Helias et incredulus Iudeorum populus convertetur ad Dominum, ita ut in eo Spiritus sanctus videatur voce sua in scriptura clamare: Pater et Filius usque modo operati sunt, et ego operor. Ut enim littera testamenti prioris proprietate quadam similitudinis videtur pertinere ad Patrem, littera testamenti novi pertinere ad Filium, ita spiritalis intelligentia, que procedit ex utraque, ad Spiritum sanctum. Et rursum, sicut ordo coniugatorum, qui primo tempore claruit, proprietate similitudinis videtur pertinere ad Patrem, ordo predicatorum, qui secundo, ad Filium, ita ordo monachorum, cui extrema magis tempora data sunt, ad Spiritum sanctum. Et secundum hoc primus quidem status ascribitur Patri, secundus Filio, tertius Spiritui sancto, licet alio modo unus dicendus sit status mundi et unus populus electorum et omnia simul sint Patris et Filii et Spiritus sancti. (Expositio in Apocalypsim, Liber introductorius, fol. 5rb–va)*

⁴¹ In the prologue of his *Psalterium decem chordarum*, Joachim allows an insight into the process of writing his main works, which were begun during a visit of one and a half year in the Cistercian monastery of Casamari: *Igitur donante ipso mox subscripti operis librum primum in ipso monasterio positus inchoavi et ex parte perfeci, secundum vero et tertium non ibi tunc nec eodem tempore sed quasi post annos duos; siquidem in tribus libris distinctum est opus istud secundum quod tres sunt persone deitatis in quibus fidei nostre plenitudo consistit, et quamvis post opus Concordie quod incepimus primo, et expositionem Apocalypsis, que ignorante me omnimodis exitum rei nescio qua Dei providentia ex eodem primo opere nascendo processit, Spiritui sancto qui et donat quod exhibemus hoc tertium opusculum dedicare decreverim, quia tamen nichil est in rebus creatis quod sic attribatur uni persone ut alienum sit a regno et operatione duarum, non inconvenienter in hoc ipso misterium rutilat Trinitatis, dum primus liber*

only the decisive role of the Holy Spirit in history, but also emphasizes the character of this spiritual insight as a gift which is given through prayer and meditation, and can neither be obtained by scholarly engagement only, however arduous it might be, nor by force. This characterization is emphasized by the decisive role of the visions in Joachim's work,⁴² of which he tells both in the *Expositio* and the *Psalterium*, and without which, according to his narratives, these works, and Joachim's insight into the Scripture and God's plan, would not have existed. This Trinitarian conception of history, together with the expectation of a higher stage of revelation, of spiritual insight not only after the second advent of Christ, but rather well within history, later became the predominant characteristic of Joachim's theology in his *Wirkungsgeschichte*.

With Joachim's three different modes of structuring and describing history – the *plenitudo* or completeness of the Apocalypse in its repeated visions, the concordances between Old and New dispensations in two parallel lines, and the threefold beginning of God's revelation in history – we have a most striking example for the co-existence between several kinds of patterns and movements in one place. None of them is purely linear or purely cyclical. The Apocalypse, of course, is not completely linear, but only on the outside, while within its sevenfold smaller circles and stories, history unrolls itself time and time again. The concordances are not linear either, because they are parallel in structure, not in chronology, inasmuch as the two dispensations are not synchronous, but subsequent to each other. Nor is the Trinitarian view of history completely linear: not only do the three persons of the Godhead never appear single, but superposed to each other, as the first person of the Godhead is still at work when the second arrives, and likewise the second during and after the advent of the third.

Moreover, none of the previous persons stops acting while his follower is at work; it would have been impossible to imagine or declare the end of God's

in quo agitur de vase musico proprietate alti misterii attribuitur Patri a quo omnia, secundus in quo agitur de numero psalmorum Sapientie divine per quam omnia, tertius in quo agitur de modo psalmodie et institutione psallentium eidem sancte Unctioni in qua omnia, que cum sit gaudium et exultatio summi Dei eos quos sacris replet muneribus letos efficit et iocundos. (Psalterium decem chordarum, Venice 1527, repr. Frankfurt a. M. 1964, fol. 227va–b, ed. Kurt-Victor SELGE, Hanover 2009). Here, too, we can see Joachim's tendency to design pattern after pattern, first attributing the three main works each to one of the three persons of the Godhead, then dividing the third writing again into three subsequent *libri* and attributing them likewise to the three persons, so that the first, second and third *liber* of the *Psalterium* are generally dedicated to the Holy Spirit, and at the same time the first and second *libri* are attributed also to the first and second person of the Godhead, while the third *liber* again is attributed to the Holy Spirit, as is the whole work in general.

⁴² On the two visions of easter and pentecost, which Joachim describes in *Expositio*, pars I, fol. 39rb–va, and *Psalterium*, Prologus, fol. 227ra–b, and their role in his work see WANNENMACHER 2005, p. 22–25.

work, like God father giving way to the Son, or the Son to the Holy Spirit. Many of the images of the *Liber Figurarum* show not only the relevant characters among the Elect in both Old and New dispensation, but also depict the persons of the Godhead and the inner-trinitarian relations in a geometric way, like the Trinitarian circles, showing the three persons in three overlapping circles, a symbol that has no beginning nor end.⁴³

With their ever proceeding, gradual revelation, spiritual understanding in humanity can grow, at least in those who are able to grasp the spiritual intelligence. And indeed, scholars of the 12th century saw themselves in a very good position to see, and to understand, more clearly than anybody before them. Like Bernard of Chartres, who described 12th century scholars as dwarfs standing on the shoulders of giants and thereby seeing further than these,⁴⁴ Joachim could have described himself as a dwarf who was standing on the shoulders of St Paul, Jerome, Augustine or Pope Gregory I, as well as those of Bernard of Clairvaux, and thereby seeing further than they ever could, though he regarded them and their authority as much greater than himself and his own.

4. Conclusion.

In this sense, history from Joachim's point of view is strictly linear, with his ever increasing spiritual intelligence. Likewise, with the chain of subsequent times of persecutions and times of peace which the elected people experiences, from Nero until the future Antichrist, as described by all authors from Victorinus to Joachim of Fiore, there is both a linear movement from bad to worse, the persecutions growing ever fiercer, and a cyclical repetition, with the same structures seven times repeated, until in the eighth stage, the eternal bliss of the last Sabbath will put an end to all these movements and to time itself. What is strikingly new in Joachim of Fiore is that he adapts all the schemes and modes of assortment together, adding pattern upon pattern, leaving nothing out, trying to order time and eternity in order to gain the clearest picture ever to be had, the most detailed information about future persecutions and bliss and the end of the times. Certainly, this endeavor shows that he was a typical child of his time, which was obsessed with ordering and numbering. But what made him truly unique was the idea that he – unlike his predecessors or contemporaries – expected a more perfect revelation yet to come and well within earthly time and circumstances: a new spiritual intelligence, a true gift of the Spirit, which

⁴³ JOACHIM OF FIORE, *Liber Figurarum*, Oxford, Corpus Christi College ms. 255A, fol. 7v, see <http://image.ox.ac.uk/show?collection=corpus&manuscript=ms255a> (viewed on January 18, 2015).

⁴⁴ JOHN OF SALISBURY, *Metalogicon*, lib. I, cap. 24; on this phrase, its origin and interpretation see SOUTHERN 1953, p. 194.

would enfold in near future, thereby inaugurating a new stage in the history of church, a higher development than anybody could have dreamt of before. Hence, Christianity's task was not anymore, as Augustine had declared, to just wait patiently and faithfully for the second advent of Christ. From now on, Christianity could expect a new development of the history of salvation well before the second advent of Christ, thus well within history. The gift of the Spirit had not been all spent at Pentecost, as there was still much more in store to be dispensed any time now, for those who could see, those who would be gifted with the spiritual intelligence, the sign of the Third Age.

Until today, Joachim has been called the father of progress, the first medieval author to really expect any progress in history. This was to become an idea which in later years was more often than not misunderstood, beginning with the claim of the Franciscans, the Dominicans or other, later religious orders of being the new spiritual men Joachim had prophesied, an identification so popular that in the 14th century it was considered perfectly credible that Joachim in person had laid out, in the mosaics of St Marc in Venice, individual portraits of St Francis and St Dominic in their monastic habits.⁴⁵

If we look at patterns and structures and their significance, the idea of progress has often been linked to Joachim's threefold model only. Sometimes it has been said that Joachim had deviated from the more traditional system of the two parallels to the more revolutionary threefold scheme. It has been suggested that the first simultaneous appearance of both structures in Joachim's writings would allow to reconstruct the approximate date when he invented this theory. Recent studies, however, have shown that this is not the case.⁴⁶ But such an analysis disregards the fact that Joachim, with his characteristic thoroughness, did not 'choose' between different systems, but rather put pattern on pattern: the two dispensations, the seven visions, and the threefold division in history, all on top of the idea of the seven ages of the world still lying underneath. History in Joachim's vision of time and until not so long ago was teleological and dominated by its predestined aim that will unfailingly be reached at the end of the time.

⁴⁵ GRECO 1612, p. 72: 'In eius quoque gratiam prophetias Sibyllae Erythraeae, & Merlini exposuit, & c. Petrus Rodulfus Tussianenensis qui fuit senogalliensis Episcopus libro primo historiarum seraphicae religionis: cum agit de effigie Sancti Francisci Assisinatis: de venerabili Ioachin, ita inquit. Margaritonus pictor sui aevi clarus inter caetera manus, in ingenii sui monumenta beatum Franciscum, quocum erat arctissima necessitudine [sic] coniunctus effinxit'. Cf. REEVES 1969, p. 96-97. It would lead us too far to name more than these earliest examples of concrete personal attributions of Joachim's characterization of the spiritual men of the future; on the reception of this idea, see WANNENMACHER 2013a.

⁴⁶ DANIEL 2013. With reference to Joachim's short treatise *De septem sigillis* however, Marjorie Reeves, too, had pointed this out, see EAD. / HIRSCH-REICH 1954.

History thus cannot but lead to salvation, and therefore, all history is nothing but history of salvation, a conception which dominated the Judeo-Christian West (and Islamic countries as well) from the end of Antiquity until well into Modern times. Hence, Joachim's model of history as that of a Western theologian of the 12th century cannot but contain linear structures aiming at their final, eternal destination. But there is more to it, and it is not as simple and one-dimensional as that.

Joachim of Fiore, who has painted history and salvation not only in words, but also in complicated and detailed illustrations modeling the generations of the Old and New Testament, of the series of persecutors of the church, the ideal monastery and the senses of Scripture, sees more than just two dimensions and one sole direction of movement.⁴⁷ For him, both linear and cyclical structures – up to a certain stage, where there is the point of no return, where all history ends – are part of the earthly pilgrimage, which goes straight and winding, forever following the spiny, and spiral, path of salvation to the heavenly Jerusalem.⁴⁸

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⁴⁷ JOACHIM OF FIORE, *Liber Figurarum*, ed. TONDELLI / REEVES / HIRSCH-REICH 1953; see also REEVES / HIRSCH-REICH 1972; RAININI 2006; ERNST 2010.

⁴⁸ A most apt image to illustrate this could be the spiral figure of the *Liber figurarum*, ms. Corpus Christi College 255A, fol. 17v, <http://image.ox.ac.uk/show?collection=corpus&manuscript=ms255a> (viewed on May 27, 2013).

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